



The Fool's Court

A trick-taking game of promises, for four players



1 The deck

The game uses a deck of **60 cards**: four kinds of agent, each ranked **1 to 15**. Rank 15 is the most influential and rank 1 the least.

AGENT	MARK	PROMISES
Assassin	♠	3
Lover	♥	2
Merchant	♣	1
Fool	♠	0

An agent's *kind* determines what it is worth when sent out on an errand (section 4). An agent's *rank* determines whether it wins an audience (section 5). The two are used at different times and never interact.

2 Overview

Four nobles compete for the ear of the monarch over a series of **nights**. At the start of each night every player privately promises how many **audiences** they will win, and then plays to reach that number exactly.

Favour is awarded for precision rather than for ambition.

Winning more audiences than you promised is penalised just as surely as winning fewer, so the difficulty of the game lies in

judging a hand accurately and then steering it to land on the number.

A season is **12 nights** of court, the last of them **Twelfth Night**. Whoever holds the most favour when it ends has the monarch's ear for the year.

*A hand is called a **night**. A promise is called a **pledge**. A trick is called an **audience**. The trump suit is called the **sway**. Points are called **favour**. The dealer is called the **steward**.*

3 Seating, the deal, and the course of a night

Four players sit in a fixed order. Play and the deal both proceed **clockwise**. The first player is the **steward** for the night; the stewardship passes one seat to the left after every night.

A night runs as follows.

1. The steward deals **15 cards** to each of the four players.
2. Each player sends **4 agents** out on errands, face down. Their kinds are that player's pledge; their ranks are irrelevant (section 4).
3. The player to the steward's left opens the first of **11 audiences**.
4. Players answer in kind where they can. The highest of the opening kind takes the audience, unless the ruling kind was played, in which case the highest of those does (section 5).

5. The winner of each audience opens the next, until every hand is empty.

6. Errands are revealed. Favour is scored on the exactness of each pledge (section 6).

7. The number of pledges kept sets the sway for the next night (section 7).

8. The stewardship passes one seat to the left, and a new night begins.

After **12 nights** the season ends and the most favour wins (section 8).

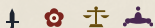
4 Making a pledge

After the deal, before any card is played, each player selects **4 cards** from their hand and places them face down in front of them. These are that player's **errands**.

A player's **pledge** is the sum of the errand values of the four cards sent, by kind. **Rank is disregarded entirely**: a Fool of 15 promises just as little as a Fool of 1.

Errands remain face down and **out of play** for the remainder of the night. 11 cards therefore remain in each hand, and **11 audiences** are contested.

All errands are revealed simultaneously when the night ends. Until then, no player knows another's pledge, nor which cards have left another's hand.



5 Playing the night

The player to the steward's left **opens** the first audience by playing any card from their hand, including one of the ruling kind.

Play continues clockwise. Each player in turn must **answer in kind** if they hold one. A player holding none may play any card at all.

The audience is won by the **highest-ranked card of the kind that opened it**, unless one or more cards of the **ruling kind** (section 7) were played, in which case the highest-ranked of those wins instead.

A card of neither the opening kind nor the ruling kind can never win an audience, whatever its rank.

The winner of an audience opens the next.

6 Winning favour

At the end of the night each player compares the audiences they won against the pledge they made, and scores as follows.

RESULT	FAVOUR
Pledged kept exactly	2 for every audience won
Pledge missed, high or low	1 for every audience won, less 2 for every audience off the pledge
Pledged nothing, won nothing	8
Pledged nothing, won audiences	-8, however many

Examples.

- Pledged 4, won 4. The pledge is kept: **8 favour**.

- Pledged 5, won 4. One short: $4 - 2 = 2$ **favour**.
- Pledged 3, won 6. Three over: $6 - 6 = 0$ **favour**.
- Pledged 2, won 0. Two short: $0 - 4 = -4$ **favour**.
- Pledged 0, won 0. The pledge is kept: **8 favour**.
- Pledged 0, won 3. Broken, and the count does not matter: **-8 favour**.

Because being wrong costs 2 favour per audience in either direction, there is no advantage in deliberately under-promising and overshooting. The only good outcome is the exact one.

7 Who holds sway

One kind of agent may **hold sway** for a night, outranking every other kind when audiences are decided (section 5). Sway is not chosen by any player. It is determined by how the *previous* night went.

The first night of a season is always played at **No Sway**, where no kind outranks any other. After that, sway passes according to how many of the four nobles kept their pledge **exactly** on the night before.

NOBLES WHO KEPT THEIR PLEDGE	SWAY NEXT NIGHT
0 nobles	 Fools
1 noble	 Merchants
2 nobles	 Lovers
3 nobles	 Assassins
4 nobles	No Sway

The ladder runs from the humblest agent to the most dangerous. When the whole court fails, the Fool rules it; when the whole court succeeds, nobody does. Sway is public knowledge before pledges are made, so every player knows which kind is dangerous while they are deciding what to promise.

8 Winning the season

A season is exactly **12 nights** long. There is no target score and no early finish: the court sits twelve times and then rises.

The twelfth and final night is **Twelfth Night**, the feast of misrule. The stewardship will have passed three full times round the table by then, so every player deals exactly three nights.

The player with the most favour after Twelfth Night wins.

Should two or more players finish tied in favour, the following tiebreakers are used, in order, to determine the winner:

1. the player who won more favour on Twelfth Night;
2. the player who made the higher pledge on Twelfth Night;
3. the player who sent out the four errands of the higher combined rank on Twelfth Night.